Introduction

The East will help us to conquer the West. Let us turn our faces towards Asia.

Vladimir Lenin[1]

It is the prestige and the wealth arising from her Asiatic position that are the foundation stones of the British Empire.

George Nathaniel Curzon[2]

This work was conceived while researching the little-known case of the 26 Baku Commissars – the execution of a number of members of the Azerbaijani Baku Commune on the night of 18 September 1918 outside the city of Krasnovodsk. In the context of the First World War and the Russian civil war, the murder of a few men might not appear very significant. But the incident quickly became a cause célèbre for Russia's new rulers, who blamed the British for the act. [3] Essentially, the case of the 26 Commissars was a small but distinct example of just how important this region of the world has always been to Anglo-Russian relations. Indeed, it was only because a British contingent had been in Baku to defend the area from Turkish encroachment that Britain was in a position to be accused of executing the Commissars. [4] It was such considerations which led to one of the founding questions of the work at hand – how did Britain's foreign policy towards South Asia affect its relationship with Soviet Russia?

The importance of Asia to Anglo-Russian relations has certainly been recognised by historians of the pre-1917 period, and the Great Game is a well-established area of historical research. It is in Asia that Britain and Russia battled for supremacy in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries; where adventure and intrigue were sought by some of the most